

Standard Operating Procedure Template

A practical SOP system for repeatable work, clear ownership, evidence, and exception handling.

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Built for clear decisions, defensible communication, and practical reuse.

How to use this template

Build the SOP with the people who do the work. Write observable actions, name the owner of each handoff, identify the record that proves completion, and test the instructions with someone who did not help draft them.

1. Define the outcome, trigger, scope, and exclusions before writing steps.
2. Document the current working process; do not invent an ideal process nobody follows.
3. Write each step as an action with an owner, input, output, quality check, and escalation path.
4. Run one supervised test, revise ambiguous steps, and record the approval.
5. Review after incidents, tool changes, policy changes, or the scheduled review date.

Test for transferability

A usable SOP lets a trained colleague complete the process consistently without relying on private context, memory, or an unrecorded handoff.

Document control

SOP title — Required	<i>[Clear verb + object, such as “Approve public sustainability claims”]</i>
SOP ID — Required	<i>[Team]-[Process]-[Number]</i>
Process owner — Required	<i>[Role, not only a person’s name]</i>
Approver — Required	<i>[Accountable role]</i>
Version — Required	<i>[1.0]</i>
Effective date — Required	<i>[YYYY-MM-DD]</i>
Next review — Required	<i>[YYYY-MM-DD or triggering event]</i>
Applies to — Required	<i>[Teams, locations, systems, or programs]</i>
Supersedes — Optional	<i>[Prior SOP ID / version]</i>
Status — Required	<i>[Draft / Approved / Retired]</i>

1. Purpose

This procedure ensures that [process outcome] is completed [consistently / safely / on time / with evidence] whenever [trigger occurs].

2. Scope and exclusions

This SOP applies to [people, systems, locations, program types, or transaction types].

It does not apply to [exceptions]. Those cases follow [other SOP, policy, legal review, or escalation route].

3. Roles and decision rights

Role	Accountability
[Process owner]	<i>[Maintains the SOP, monitors performance, and approves routine changes]</i>
[Executor]	<i>[Completes the procedure and records evidence]</i>
[Reviewer]	<i>[Checks defined quality criteria before release or handoff]</i>
[Approver]	<i>[Accepts final accountability or authorizes exceptional action]</i>
[Escalation contact]	<i>[Resolves blocked, unsafe, noncompliant, or high-impact cases]</i>

4. Definitions, prerequisites, and safeguards

Key terms	<i>[Define abbreviations, thresholds, statuses, and specialized terms]</i>
Required access	<i>[Systems, folders, permissions, credentials, or physical access]</i>
Required inputs	<i>[Approved brief, request form, source data, contract, policy, or ticket]</i>
Tools	<i>[Application, worksheet, checklist, equipment, or communication channel]</i>
Safeguards	<i>[Privacy, safety, accessibility, records retention, approval, or review requirements]</i>
Stop condition	<i>[Condition that requires pausing and escalating before continuing]</i>

5. Procedure

Step	Owner	Action	Evidence / output	Quality check / escalation
1	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
2	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
3	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
4	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
5	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
6	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
7	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]
8	[Role]	[Start with a verb. Describe one observable action and the required input.]	[File, record, status, approval, or handoff]	[Pass condition and escalation trigger]

6. Decision rules and exceptions

Condition	Required response
If [condition A]	Then [action, owner, and deadline]
If [condition B]	Then [action, owner, and deadline]
If information is incomplete	Return to [requester / source] using [message or form]; do not infer required facts.
If a high-risk issue appears	Stop, preserve the record, and escalate to [role] before publishing, paying, signing, deleting, or committing.
If the tool is unavailable	Use [approved fallback] and reconcile the record in [system] within [time].

7. Quality controls and records

Completion evidence	[Record that demonstrates the process finished]
Storage location	[Approved system / folder / case record]
Retention period	[Duration and governing policy]
Reviewer sample	[Percent, frequency, or risk-based rule]
Primary KPI	[Metric, target, source, and review frequency]
Failure signal	[Metric or incident that triggers root-cause review]

8. Training and rollout

- Identify who must read, practice, or acknowledge the SOP.
- Provide one realistic practice case and one exception case.
- Record the trainer, completion date, learner, and any observed gap.
- Publish the approved version in one authoritative location and retire duplicate copies.

9. Change log and approvals

Version	Date	Change	Prepared by	Approved by
[1.0]	[YYYY-MM-DD]	[Initial release]	[Author / owner]	[Approver]
[]	[]	[]	[]	[]
[]	[]	[]	[]	[]

SOP quality checklist

- The process has one owner, a clear trigger, and named roles.
- Every step starts with a verb and identifies its input, output, and evidence.
- Decision points, stop conditions, and escalation paths are visible.
- The SOP was tested by someone outside the drafting group and revised where needed.
- The approved version, effective date, review trigger, and retirement of obsolete copies are recorded.

Use note: This is a general planning resource—not legal, tax, accounting, certification, or financial advice. Verify applicable requirements and obtain qualified review.